

Society in the expansionist Aztec Empire was deeply militaristic. A boy had to prove himself a warrior before he could be considered a man. Noble Aztec youths joined warrior societies and progressed through the ranks by taking more captives for sacrifice.



which extended nearly 25,000 miles (40,000 kilometers) long and was dotted at regular intervals with rest houses that facilitated rapid transit for the army and provided a very efficient system of communication across the far-flung Inca domains. At the same time, the Inca domestication of the llama as a beast of burden made it easier to transport heavy loads across the empire.

Unlike the Aztecs, the Incas actively sought to spread their own language (Quechua) and system of religious beliefs, which was initially based around the worship of Inti (the sun god), but which came to feature prominently Viracocha—a supreme creation god and therefore considered a more suitable deity for a conquering power. They also dispatched colonists (*mitmaq*), shifting troublesome groups into more pacified areas to dilute their resistance and creating networks of loyal settlers on the fringes of the empire. Although definitive population statistics are not known, by the early 16th century the Inca Empire—which the Incas called Tawantinsuyu (“The Realm of Four Quarters”)—consisted of about 4–6 million people in total, operating to the advantage of the Inca minority and their subjects.

Despite its many strengths, the highly centralized nature of the Inca Empire proved fatal in the early 1530s, when

Spanish invaders led by Pizarro captured the Sapa Inca Atahualpa; without their leader, the Incas rapidly collapsed.

The new colonizers

The Aztecs and the Incas built the first true empires in their regions of the Americas. They were able to do so by creating food surpluses through irrigation projects, thus releasing a large proportion of their population to fight in the armies that conducted their campaigns of expansion. They also reorganized the traditional tribal structure to favor a warrior and noble elite. In both cases, the momentum of conquest demanded further wars to reward the warrior caste or to provide an incentive for newly conquered peoples to remain loyal and thus to gain the rewards of participation in new campaigns.

Neither the Aztecs nor the Incas survived long enough to govern after their expansion slowed down. Had they done so, they might have developed strategies to bring long-term stability to their empires, or might have declined to the status of competing city-states fighting to control limited resources. Instead, the Spanish conquest of the Aztecs in 1521 and their defeat of the last Incas by 1572 put an end to the ambitions of both empires and left the Spanish firmly established as colonial rulers in the region for the next 300 years. ■